

Abbreviations

A WORD OR PHRASE THAT IS WRITTEN IN A SHORTENED FORM IS CALLED AN ABBREVIATION.

The English language contains many abbreviations, which are used to represent longer words or phrases in speech, or where space is limited. In some cases, the abbreviation is better known than the full name.

Common abbreviations

The way an abbreviation is written usually depends on the category to which it belongs. Often, a period is used to represent missing text. For abbreviated Latin phrases, periods are used after each letter. Abbreviations that are formed from the initial letters of a group of words usually don't use periods.

REAL WORLD

NASA

One of the world's most recognized abbreviations is the name of the American government agency NASA, which stands for the National Aeronautics and Space Administration. The first letter from each word forms this acronym—an abbreviation that is pronounced as a word, not as separate letters. The NASA logo shown here is on the side of a space shuttle.



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Picking the right words

182–183 ▶

The symbol @ is an abbreviation for “at” and is used in **e-mail addresses** and **text messages**.

Abbreviation	Words in full
3-D	three-dimensional
a.m.	<i>ante meridiem</i> (Latin); before noon (English)
b.	born (indicating birth date)
BCE	before the Common Era
Brit.	British
C	Centigrade or Celsius
CE	Common Era
dept.	department
DIY	do-it-yourself
ed.	edition or editor
e.g.	<i>exempli gratia</i> (Latin); for example (English)
est.	established or estimated
EST	Eastern Standard Time
etc.	<i>et cetera</i> (Latin); and the rest (English)
EU	European Union
F	Fahrenheit
FAQ	frequently asked questions
GMT	Greenwich Mean Time
HTML	HyperText Markup Language

Abbreviation	Words in full
i.e.	<i>id est</i> (Latin); that is (English)
IOU	I owe you
LED	light-emitting diode
long.	longitude
MD	medical doctor
Mr.	Mister
Mrs.	Mistress (referring to wife)
PDF	Portable Document Format
percent	<i>per centum</i> (Latin); in each hundred (English)
p.m.	<i>post meridiem</i> (Latin); after noon (English)
PM	Prime Minister
Pres.	President
P.S.	<i>post scriptum</i> (Latin); written after (English)
PTO	please turn over
SMS	Short Message Service
UK	United Kingdom
US	United States
USB	Universal Serial Bus
www	World Wide Web